

PART 2.

Intergenerational Perspectives into Family Relationships and Processes

- One of the hallmarks of family systems theory...
- Family problems and recommendations for change can be uncovered by studying *family patterns from an intergenerational perspective*.

Generations

- A group of people born and living around the same time, typically about **20–30 years apart** in a family lineage.
- Include ties with grandparents, aunts, uncles, cousins, and etc.

Generational Processes

- Family members have connection to traditions, emotional tendencies, values, and ways of relating
- These things are passed down, reinforced, repeated, practiced, and established over generations,
- And become the **family heritage** and determine the **lifestyle or culture** of each family
 - Unique in each family
- Many aspects of family life grow out of, and build upon these processes

What is passed down through generational processes

- Physical traits
- Personalities and abilities
- Emotional, intellectual, developmental, interpersonal, and experiential traits are also inherited from one generation to the next
- Values
- Ways of relating

What do generational processes do to us?

- They have an enormous influence on:
 - What we believe
 - How we relate to others
 - What is important and unimportant to us
 - Whether we think the world is a friendly or unfriendly place
 - Our aspirations and values
 - The attitudes we have toward other people
 - Religion
 - How we handle conflict, intimacy, anger, love, hate, and life in general

Mechanisms of Generational Processes

- How do generational processes influence us? Through what?

Why are generational processes so influential?

1. Permanent in some extent
 - We cannot escape or cancel them

Why are generational processes so influential?

2. They start making a difference at the earliest stages of our lives.

- They involve our deepest feelings of who we are (self-worth) and what is important in life
- We don't and can't choose them

Can some parts of generational processes be altered?

Some parts can be changed but it is very difficult even if you recognize that the change is necessary.

- We don't know how to change them
- We don't have the resources or strength to change them
- We don't want to pay the emotional and interpersonal price
- Most of us just live with them as they are; or some people cut family ties

Alliance

- A supportive or cooperative bond based on a shared purpose; occurs when two or more individuals in a family become close and align themselves as a unit in the family
- Examples of healthy alliances
 - A very close marital subsystem, the parental alliance “in charge” in the family becomes the executive subsystem in the family, responsible for disciplining and socializing the children.

Coalition

- a typically *dysfunctional* alliance in which two or more family members unite against, exclude, or undermine another family member, thereby affecting family boundaries, hierarchy, and power.

Cross-Generational Alliance

- an alignment of support or shared purpose between family members from different generational subsystems, such as a parent and child

- Example:

A father and his teenage daughter work together to plan a surprise birthday dinner for the mother. They coordinate the meal, keep the plan confidential, and support one another in carrying it out.

Cross-Generational Coalition

- A cross-generational coalition occurs when family members from different generations align against, or in ways that substantially affect, another family member, thereby altering the family's power balance.
- Example of problematic *cross-generational* coalition:
 - A wife of a workaholic husband forms an unusually strong alliance with her son, that excludes the husband or other children in the family

- Shifts family boundaries, often leading to triangulation.
- Child may carry loyalty conflicts or role confusion (becoming a "spouse surrogate" or "parentified child").
- In a high-conflict marriage, a father may confide in his teenage daughter about his marital problems, creating a father-daughter alliance that undermines the marital dyad and burdens the child with adult responsibilities.

Problematic cross-generational Alliances with Diffuse Boundaries (Jessica's story)

- My mom always wanted to be my friend.
 - She was always saying, "I want to be your friend, I want to be your friend."
 - And I used to tell her, "You're my mother. You're supposed to be my mom, not a friend,"
 - Maybe she just wanted to know what was going on in my life, but I wanted her to be my mother.
 - Maybe it had something to do with her family as she grew up.
 - Her mother got divorced when my mom was 3, and they formed a really close cross-generational alliance.
 - Maybe it worked for them OK, but it was uncomfortable for me.
- ➔ **What is the problem in this mother-daughter subsystem?**

Principle of Cross-Generational Alliance and Coalition

- Having clear-cut generational boundaries about leadership, responsibility, support, and emotional feelings, are helpful
 - When the boundaries are clear, it helps the adults and children develop in healthy ways
- Cross-generational alliances that are too strong and coalitions often lead to emotional and interpersonal difficulties for the adults and children

(2) Generational Transmissions

- The process of transmitting from one generation to the next such things as ways of behaving, ways of feeling, ways of relating, ways of defining reality, and ways of coping with intimacy and distance
- Highlight how **patterns and beliefs** are carried forward through time (what gets passed on).
- **Principle:** *Families tend to transmit their (desirable & undesirable) style of life to each new generation.*

Generational Transmissions: Example

- My great grandma on Mom's side had a terrible temper.
- My grandpa was her oldest child and he was expected to take care of his siblings from the day they were born.
- If they even made one peep she beat him.
- As he grew up, he inherited his mother's temper.
- After he married, his wife finally forbade him to touch her children when he got mad because he could not control his temper.
- My mom also has a temper, and I've noticed some of my siblings have strong tempers.
- Apparently, it has decreased with each new generation, but I wonder how long this little bit of my great grandma will last.

Intergenerational transmission of Healthy Generational Alliances (**Eric's story**)

- My parents were a great team.
- They'd get their heads together and think through what they wanted before they acted.
- They used to call their sessions the "meeting of the board of directors."
- They'd let us have a say in decisions, especially the ones that involved our friends and things like that, but they were together in their ideas enough that we didn't even have to decide whose idea we liked better.
- I think my wife and I are as good a team as they were.

Intergenerational Transmissions

- Considerable evidence that generational transmission occurs in:
 - Quality of marriage
 - Abusive behaviors (substance abuse, sexual abuse, physical abuse, etc.)
 - Traditions of self-control, moderations and coping with extreme difficulties without abuse
 - Mental health and illness

Am I doomed? Can generational processes
ever be stopped?!!

- A **transitional character** is a person in a family lineage who consciously breaks destructive or unhealthy intergenerational patterns and creates healthier ones, thereby changing the direction of the family system for future generations (Carlfred Broderick, 1988).

Key Features of a transitional character

- **Conscious Awareness** – The individual recognizes dysfunctional family patterns (e.g., abuse, addiction, secrecy, rigid roles).
- **Intentional Change** – Rather than unconsciously repeating what was handed down, the person chooses alternative behaviors, values, and coping strategies.
 - **Deliberateness** (determination)
- **New Legacy** – By altering their own way of living and relating, they pass healthier dynamics to their children, influencing the family's trajectory.
- Maintaining **emotional distance** from family of origin
 - It doesn't mean emotional cut off
- Allowing oneself to **learn new ways** of interacting with other people **outside the parental home**, to choose new ways of living, loving, feeling, and acting